

Function(al) Technology

For our twelfth anniversary, we wanted to continue the theme of using the number to signify something, because it might be some time before we can do that again. Numbers after 12 aren't really something people easily relate to – 10 is a decade, 12 is a dozen, but 13 to 19 are not really numbers that lend themselves to catchy themes. We'd have to wait another eight years till we got to 20 before we'd be able to really exploit numbers again.

However, 12 really did fit well this year for another reason: it's a fitting farewell (of sorts) to aspects of the keyboard, especially the function keys, which went from being super-important shortcuts to something we almost never use anymore. Technology changes, we change, our needs and wants change, and this change is the only constant.

What is technology really, and what does it do for us? Is it just an enabler, allowing us to do what we couldn't before? Is it a simplifier, that helps make tedious tasks easier and quicker to achieve? Perhaps technology is just something that helps us "function" better – at work, at home, in school, as human beings, as organic constructs prone to breakdowns... you get the drift.

Looking back at the 12 years of Digit thus far – while going through all the PDFs of the past issues (find them on the DVD) – apart from all the sentimental reminiscing that occurred, it was obvious how much technology has changed our lives. It was also obvious how much this magazine has evolved.

Back in 2001, the need of the day was information. People wanted to learn about this almost alien, yet wonderful thing called technology – the PC, the web and technology in general was something novel. The "function" of this magazine back then was clearly teaching you about technology, how something works, how to tell good products from bad, how to use them better, etc.

Of course, the primary objective of this magazine will always be to open your eyes to the "new" (and not always "improved"), but you have more advanced needs now. The function that technology plays in your life has changed, and technology itself is the one that changed it!

From the days when we'd look at a humble PC in awe, today all of us can interface with new technologies with ease. The latest phone with a

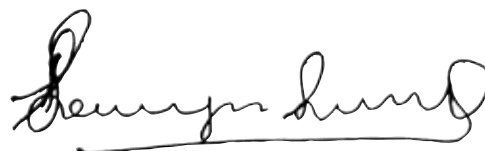
brand new OS that we've never used is not even a challenge anymore. Sure we might fumble a few times in the beginning, but we get used to it in no time. Is that because the technology has become simpler to understand and use, or is it because we've been exposed to technology for so long now that it's almost intuitive, and we learn quicker? A little of both is perhaps the reason, but the result of that is what's important – we no longer need to get in on the ground floor of a new technology to be able to use it effectively.

Take a simple function of commuting – what we did on foot became horseback riding, then the wheel brought forth the cart, followed by the automobile, then airplanes and finally space shuttles. Technology helped make it possible for us to travel thousands of kilometers in a few hours, yet it's also technology that reduced the very need to travel itself.

From having to travel to meet a friend who stayed far away, first we made it possible to write to him, then we reduced the time between responses by inventing the telephone and fax, then came email, video chats and finally social networking. Today, a lot of us are able to feel connected to people we haven't met face-to-face in years. We're also able to e-commute to work, be available anytime, anywhere... our functional need of being connected – to friends and to work – has never been better served by technology.

This is just a miniscule example of one of the thousands of ways technology has changed the way we function. The technologies and services that will win out in the end are those that best serve our thousands of varied yet important functions – meet people, learn something, pay bills, earn money, clean my room, help me live longer, snoop on friends, entertain me, expand my vision, give me ideas...

Put simply, this is what Digit's been doing over the past 12 years as well – ensuring that you always find the most functional path forwards, by being your technology navigator. Here's to many more years of collaboration between you and this brand we all love. Please keep the feedback coming – how else will we know how you function, and how we should function for you? 




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